

BORNEAN RAINFOREST

Southeast Asia's treasure trove of rare species

At around 140 million years of age, Borneo's lowland rainforest is one of the oldest and most biodiverse in the world. But the forest's diversity is also what makes it attractive to commercial exploitation. The lowland forests boast 267 species of large hardwood trees, 60 percent of which are endemic to Borneo. Estimates put forest loss in the region at 30 percent since 1970, due mainly to the logging of hardwoods for the global timber market and the conversion of land to agricultural use. Increasing fragmentation of the rainforest presents difficulties for endangered wide-ranging species such as orangutans, which require large, continuous tracts of forest for survival. Also, there is a staggering 99 percent drop in species diversity just a couple of yards into a plantation compared to the untouched rainforest.

High, green island heart

Currently just over half of the island retains its forest cover, with the majority consisting of lowland rainforest below 3,300 ft (1,000 m). The cooler, higher-altitude center of the island—now known internationally as the Heart of Borneo—is covered with unbroken mountainous rainforest, which has so far suffered less from logging and the encroachment of agriculture, mainly because the terrain is less suitable. Other important habitats for wildlife in Borneo include swamp forests and mangroves.

18 mammal species in Borneo's mountain rainforest exist **nowhere else on Earth**



SHRUB FROG

The third-largest island on Earth >

IMMUNE TO DANGER
Pitcher plants use bright colors and sweet smells to attract insects to their sticky, fluid-filled "pitchers." Prey that drowns in the liquid is digested by the plant. Shrub frogs are unaffected by the fluid, and lay their eggs in the pitchers, where they develop safely from predators.

SUN BEAR

> 44 of which are found nowhere else in the world

HONEY HUNTER
The Borneo sun bear is found only in the island's rainforests. It uses its large claws to rip open beehives and termite nests in search of honey and insects to eat. It also consumes fruit from various rainforest trees and plays an important role in seed dispersal.

SLIPPER ORCHID

WONDERFUL ORCHIDS
Borneo has 2,500–3,000 orchid species; 51 new kinds were discovered between 2007 and 2010. The region is home to rare flowers, such as the Rothschild's slipper orchid—beautiful and endangered.

< 221 mammal species live here, 44 of which are found nowhere else in the world